



Getting On Track

You don't have to be a software development company to worry about project management solutions—dotProject can be customised to your needs too

Nimish Chandiramani

When you think “project management”, you normally think Microsoft Project, which in turn makes you think that project management solutions are for software development companies only. In a sense, this is true—the first solutions were indeed designed to make software development easier. They enabled confusion-free collaboration, and provided a way to analyse the development team's efficiency at the end. If you're reading this and thinking, “I need this too!” we won't blame you. The benefits of a project management solution should be available to any organisation whose business is based on projects from clients, and more so when deadlines are tight.

Sadly, many project management solutions—both open source and commercial—are still built with software projects in mind, but there are a few that can be customised to suit anyone. One such solution is dotProject, which is very easy to get used to, and works for anyone whose work comes as projects.

Prelude

To run dotProject, you'll need a dedicated PC of modest configuration; this is a Web-based solution meant for the LAMP (Linux-Apache-MySQL-PHP) platform, so running it on a Linux-based machine is advisable. If you prefer Windows, install Wampserver (<http://www.wampserver.com>), which automatically installs Apache, MySQL and PHP on your PC. We'll use this approach for now.

The first thing you need to do after installing Wamp is to fix the most important security hole—the administrative user for MySQL (root) has no password. To fix this, start PHPMyAdmin by clicking on the Wamp icon in the system tray and choosing PHPMyAdmin. This lets you administer your database from within your browser. Click on the Privileges link, and you'll see a user overview. Click on the little icon next to the entry for “root” to edit it. Scroll down a bit, and you'll be able to change the password. Now open `C:\wamp\apps\phpmyadmin2.10.1\config.inc.php`, search for `$cfg['Servers'][$i]['pass-`